

white mobs: In Memphis 46 people were killed, in New Orleans 40. Opinion among hardline anti-Southern Republicans, known as Republican Radicals, was outraged, and much of the ire was directed at Johnson, who had vetoed a bill to extend the life of the Freedmen's Bureau, a federal agency set up under Lincoln to protect Black rights in the South. Worse still, he went on to veto a Civil Rights Bill that would have given citizenship to Black people on the same terms as the rest of the population. Infuriated radicals and moderates came together to override both vetoes and push the measures through.

The conflict simmered for the next two years, eventually polarizing into a struggle between Johnson and his secretary of war, Edwin M. Stanton, a champion of the Republican Radical cause. To prevent Johnson from purging his cabinet of radicals, Congress took the unprecedented step of passing a Tenure of Office Act, forbidding the president from removing high-ranking officials without the Senate's approval. When Johnson flouted the act by seeking to replace Stanton, the power struggle between legislature and executive came to a head. The House voted to impeach the president—the first time that it had done so in its 80-year history—and Johnson was duly forced to stand trial. In the event, enough moderate Republican senators rallied to the president's cause to deny the impeachers the two-thirds majority they needed by just one vote. Johnson had been saved by the skin of his teeth, and served out the remaining eight months of his term. He was succeeded in office by the Union war hero Ulysses S. Grant. Johnson retained support in the South, and in time was re-elected to the Senate, serving for five months before his death from a stroke. Since then, his reputation has risen and fallen in line with attitudes to Reconstruction as a whole. Generally, historians have placed Johnson in the category of presidents found wanting.